

Disciplinary and Grievance Procedure

Policy code: POL-HR-040. Owner: Chief People Officer. Effective date: 1 September 2024.
Version: 1.

1. Purpose and scope

This procedure explains how Meridian Instruments Ltd deals with concerns about an employee's conduct and how employees can raise a grievance about their work. It aims to resolve issues fairly, consistently and as early as possible. It applies to all employees at all sites. Where local law in the Netherlands, the United States or Malaysia requires a different process, the local People team will apply the procedure with any necessary adjustments and will explain them to the employee in writing.

This procedure does not apply to performance concerns during probation, which are handled under the Probation Policy (POL-HR-011), or to concerns about wrongdoing in the business, which should be raised under the Speak Up Policy (POL-CORP-004).

2. Principles

- Issues should be raised and dealt with promptly and without unreasonable delay.
- Meridian will investigate before taking any formal disciplinary action.
- Employees will be told the allegations against them and given the evidence before any hearing.
- Employees have the right to be accompanied at formal meetings by a colleague or a trade union representative.
- No disciplinary action beyond an informal discussion will be taken until the case has been fully investigated.
- Employees have the right to appeal against any formal outcome.
- Records are kept confidential and held in Keel in line with the Records Retention Schedule (POL-CORP-008).

3. Informal resolution

Many minor conduct issues, such as occasional lateness or a lapse in following a procedure, can be resolved by an informal conversation between the employee and their line manager. The manager should explain the concern, listen to the employee's explanation, agree what needs to change and by when, and keep a brief note in Keel. An informal discussion is not a disciplinary sanction and is not recorded as a warning.

4. Investigation and suspension

Where the matter is more serious or informal action has not worked, the manager must contact the People team at peoplehelp@meridian-instruments.example before taking further action. An investigating officer, who will not be the person who decides the outcome, will gather facts, which may include interviewing the employee and witnesses and reviewing records.

In cases of alleged gross misconduct, or where an investigation could be compromised, the employee may be suspended on full pay. Suspension is not a disciplinary sanction and does not imply guilt. It will be kept as short as possible and reviewed at least every two weeks.

5. Disciplinary hearing

If the investigation shows there is a case to answer, the employee will be invited in writing to a disciplinary hearing, with at least five working days' notice. The invitation will set out the allegations, include the investigation report and evidence, state the possible outcomes and

confirm the right to be accompanied.

If the chosen companion is unavailable, the employee may propose another date within five working days of the original. At the hearing the employee can respond to the allegations, present evidence and call relevant witnesses. The outcome will be confirmed in writing, normally within five working days of the hearing.

6. Disciplinary stages

The stages below are normally followed in order, but Meridian may start at a later stage depending on the seriousness of the conduct.

Stage | Typical use | Live period

Informal discussion | minor first issue | not recorded as warning

First written warning | misconduct or repeated minor issues | 6 months

Final written warning | further or serious misconduct | 12 months

Dismissal | further misconduct during a live final warning, or gross misconduct | n/a

A warning is live for the period shown from the date of the outcome letter. After it expires it is disregarded for future disciplinary purposes, although the record remains on file.

Alternatives to dismissal, such as demotion or transfer, may be considered at the final stage where appropriate and agreed.

7. Gross misconduct

Gross misconduct is conduct so serious that it may justify dismissal without notice for a first offence. Examples include:

- theft, fraud or deliberate falsification of records, including expense claims or product test results;
- violence, bullying, harassment or discrimination;
- serious breaches of health and safety rules, including disabling gas detection equipment;
- being unfit for work through alcohol or drugs;
- serious breaches of the Code of Conduct (POL-CORP-001), including bribery;
- serious misuse of personal or confidential data;
- retaliation against someone who has spoken up.

8. Disciplinary appeals

An employee may appeal against any formal outcome by writing to the People team within 5 working days of receiving the outcome letter, stating the grounds of appeal. The appeal will be heard, wherever possible, by a more senior manager who was not involved previously. The appeal decision is final.

9. Raising a grievance

A grievance is a concern, problem or complaint that an employee raises about their work, working environment or working relationships.

1. Where possible, raise the matter informally with your line manager first. If the grievance concerns your manager, raise it with their manager or the People team.
2. If informal resolution does not work, submit a formal grievance in writing to peoplehelp@meridian-instruments.example. A grievance should be raised within 3 months of the event it relates to, unless there is a good reason for delay.
3. A grievance meeting will be held within 10 working days of receiving the written grievance. You have the right to be accompanied.

4. The outcome will be confirmed in writing, normally within five working days of the meeting.
5. If you are not satisfied, you may appeal within 5 working days of the outcome. The appeal will be heard by a manager not previously involved and the decision is final.

10. Overlapping disciplinary and grievance cases

If an employee raises a grievance during a disciplinary process, the disciplinary process may be paused briefly to deal with the grievance, or both may be handled together where they are related.

11. Support

Formal processes can be stressful. Employees involved in a disciplinary or grievance process, including witnesses, can use the Employee Assistance Programme for confidential support. Managers can seek guidance at any time from the People team at peoplehelp@meridian-instruments.example.

12. Review

This procedure is reviewed every two years by the Chief People Officer, Adaeze Okafor.